

8 Further Objections

Part 1: Weirdness, Supervenience, and Semantic Objections

In the last three chapters, I have addressed three of the most prominent objections to intuitionism, those concerned with intuitionism's ability to account for moral knowledge, its ability to explain and resolve moral disagreement, and its ability to account for moral motivation. In this chapter, I address miscellaneous further objections.

8.1 The argument from weirdness

I begin with J. L. Mackie's famous contention that objective moral properties would be 'queer'.¹ This objection is voiced in conversation more often than it is put in writing. Philosophers often dismiss moral realism, intuitionism, and many other views as too 'weird', 'spooky', or 'mysterious' for them.² This may well be the main source of resistance to intuitionism. No matter how forcefully I make the rest of the arguments in this book, intuitionism will never be accepted as long as philosophers find it 'weird'.

Mackie had a few specific things to say about how moral properties would be queer that I will not discuss in this section, as they are dealt with elsewhere.³ Here, my focus is his general contention that moral properties would be properties 'of a very strange sort, utterly different from anything else in the universe'.⁴

Anti-realists may be right in pegging objective values as strange. But how would this be a reason for denying their existence? Perhaps the argument is:

1. Objective values would be weird.
2. If something would be weird, then it (probably) does not exist.
3. Therefore, objective values (probably) do not exist.

What does it mean for something to be 'weird'? This might seem a frivolous question, were it not for the enormous influence that the sense of 'weirdness' has on what positions are respected and seriously investigated in philosophy. Consider four interpretations of the notion:

First: Perhaps to say a kind of thing is weird is to say that it is counter-intuitive that things of that kind exist. But Mackie does not accept intuition as a justification for believing (or disbelieving) anything, so this is an unlikely interpretation. And if Mackie did accept the validity of intuition, then we could simply appeal to the various intuitions cited in this book to show that objective values exist. Since Mackie thinks a claim to objectivity is embedded in all ordinary moral thinking and discourse,[5] the case that objectivism is counter-intuitive would be a tough one to make.

Second: Perhaps to say x is weird is to say that x is very dissimilar from all or most other things that exist. In this case, premise (2) becomes: 'If something is very dissimilar from other things that exist, then it (probably) does not exist'. Why should we accept this? Consider this partial list of what exists:

time	mental states
space	physical states
numbers	aesthetic properties
propositions	fields (e.g., the gravitational field)
substances	the past
properties	dispositional properties
relationships	moral properties

One could say of any item on that list that it is utterly different from everything else that exists. At least it seems that way, and yet all those things seem clearly to exist. This isn't just the trivial point that everything is different from everything else; the point here is that the above things are each very different, different in kind, from everything else. So, on the face of it, this version of the argument from weirdness goes nowhere.

Third: Perhaps anti-realism about weirdness is correct. Perhaps 'weirdness' is the property of causing some sort of reaction in human observers, such as surprise, wonder, or disbelief; perhaps '\$x\$ is weird' expresses a non-cognitive reaction towards \$x\$; or perhaps there simply is no such thing as weirdness. If moral anti-realism is true, then I think anti-realism about weirdness is almost certainly true. But then it is very unclear how calling something weird could count as giving evidence against its existence.

Fourth: Perhaps to say something is weird is to say we do not clearly understand its nature. This would be a version of the third interpretation, and the same objection applies: it is unclear how our failure to clearly understand something is evidence against its existence. Nor do I see reason, in any case, for thinking we do not understand moral properties reasonably well.

On this score, the anti-realist might point to intuitionists' failure to explain the nature of moral properties. But intuitionists have said many things about the nature of moral properties—that goodness is an objective property; that it depends on but is not reducible to the natural properties of a thing; that it comes in degrees; that awareness of it intrinsically provides us with reasons for action; that it is the opposite of badness; that things which have it are appropriate objects of such attitudes as approval and admiration; that it is a property that such things as happiness, knowledge, benevolence, and honesty have in common.

Still, the anti-realist might point to intuitionists' failure to define moral concepts. But this is no reason for denying that we understand moral concepts, nor for denying that they refer to anything. We often understand a concept well enough to know that it applies to some things, without being able to define it. I cannot define 'table', and I don't believe I have ever met anyone who could.[6] But I still know there are tables. For a more interesting example, analytic philosophers have tried for 40 years to define 'knowledge', but no definition has been generally accepted, and in my view, every definition proposed is subject to decisive counter-examples. But no one thinks this proves that we don't understand 'knows' or that it doesn't apply to anything. Indeed, my own view is that no correct, non-stipulative definition of any philosophically interesting concept has ever been produced. Obviously, I cannot show that here, but I can report that I know of no such definition that has been generally accepted in any branch of philosophy. The intuitionists' inability to define 'good', therefore, hardly shows goodness to be queer in a way that justifies denying its existence.

8.2 Troubles with supervenience

8.2.1 Mackie's objection

All or nearly all realists agree that moral properties depend on non-moral properties. For example, if Pol Pot is evil, there must be something else *about* him that *makes* him evil—say, his disregard for human life, his tyrannical personality, and so on. And whatever this property or collection of properties is, any other person who had it would also thereby be evil. We express this idea by saying that moral properties 'supervene on' non-moral properties.⁷

J. L. Mackie finds this dependence of moral properties on non-moral properties mysterious:

What is the connection between the natural fact that an action is a piece of deliberate cruelty—say, causing pain just for fun—and the moral fact that it is wrong? It cannot be an entailment, a logical or semantic necessity. Yet it is not merely that the two features occur together. The wrongness must somehow be 'consequential' or 'supervenient'; it is wrong because it is a piece of deliberate cruelty. But just what in the world is signified by this 'because'?⁸

He goes on to worry that our awareness of this relationship would require a mysterious 'intuition'. Apart from that, the above quotation is the entire exposition of the objection.

Pace Mackie, I do not believe that the above passage articulates any objection to moral realism at all. I see nothing there that provides a reason for denying that a property can depend on other properties. Mackie has identified nothing problematic about this relation; all he says about it is that it is not logical or semantic entailment. The rest of the passage's content seems to consist of a tone of incredulity.

Perhaps Mackie's idea is that this dependence relation is queer, just as moral properties are, or that intuitionists' failure to define it is a reason for denying that it exists. If so, my replies in section 8.1 apply.

However, I do not deny that there are philosophical puzzles concerning supervenience; we shall see some in the following subsections.

***8.2.2 Objections to the notion of *prima facie* rightness**

Some intuitionists, myself included, believe that our intuitions tell us, not that certain kinds of action are always right, but that certain kinds of action are *prima facie* right. A *prima facie* right type of action is a type of action that *tends* to be right, or is morally right *other things being equal*.⁹ The reason for introducing this notion is that all or most of the generalizations we can think of about what is right or wrong have exceptions. For instance, it is generally wrong to burn cats. But if the cat had a deadly, contagious disease, and the microbes could only be killed by burning, then it would be alright to burn a cat. Furthermore, it proves exceedingly difficult to state all the conditions under which cat-burning would be permissible. So some intuitionists say that we can merely see that causing suffering is *prima facie* wrong—it is wrong as long as no special exculpatory or justificatory circumstances exist.

Peter Strawson objects that this idea conflicts with the original idea that the moral properties of a thing follow from its non-moral properties. If *B* follows from *A*, then *B* must be present whenever *A* is, not merely 'tend to be' present when *A* is, or be present *most* of the time when *A* is. Furthermore, to say a type of action 'tends to be wrong' is just to say that *most* actions of that kind are wrong. But a statement of the form 'Most *A*'s are *B*' cannot be a necessary truth. Yet intuitionists claim the basic moral truths to be necessary.¹⁰

This objection has a few false premises. Intuitionists think that the moral status of an action follows from the *total set* of its non-moral properties, not from any one *prima facie* right-making or wrong-making feature. Nor does 'Cat-burning is *prima facie* wrong' mean 'Most cat-burnings are wrong'. It means that an act's being a case of cat-burning counts against that action; it is logically compatible with this that *most* of the time there *do* exist exculpatory circumstances. (Imagine that most of the world's cats had a deadly disease, etc.)¹¹

To see that this conception of *prima facie* rightness is perfectly coherent, compare an example from classical physics. Newton tells us that a body will accelerate in the direction of the net force acting on it. He also gives us a law of gravity governing *one* of the forces that acts on bodies. It is physically necessary that a massive body experience a gravitational pull—something that has a tendency to accelerate it—towards any other massive body. If there are no other forces, then the body will accelerate in that direction. But there may be other forces, such as electric or magnetic ones, that overcome that pull.

Prima facie rightness and wrongness are analogous to 'forces' that pull an action towards rightness or wrongness.¹² Just as, in classical physics, the acceleration of any body is determined by the physical configuration of the system it belongs to, so the rightness or wrongness of actions is determined by their non-moral features (including relational features). Just as it is physically necessary that a given configuration generates a certain amount of gravitational force, it is (metaphysically) necessary that a given non-moral property generates a certain degree of *prima facie* wrongness. Just as the law of gravity does not mean that most objects are falling (perhaps most are being supported by counter-balancing forces), the principle of the *prima facie* wrongness of cat-burning does not mean that most cat-burnings are wrong.

Admittedly, this analogy is misleading in at least two ways. First, in the case of classical physics, there is a simple mathematical law for the composition of forces (that is, how to compute 'total force' when given the individual forces): the parallelogram law. I do not mean to suggest that the law for the composition of *prima facie* rightnesses and wrongnesses (the principle that takes you from the various right-making and wrong-making features of an action to its overall degree of rightness or wrongness) is similar in form to the parallelogram law for the composition of forces, nor indeed that it has any simple mathematical formulation. The only point here is that there is nothing incoherent in the general framework of *prima facie* duties.

Second, in classical physics, a force can be outweighed by a greater force, but it cannot be removed when the conditions specified in the relevant force law obtain. For instance, gravitational force can be counterbalanced, but there is no way to remove the gravitational force a body experiences, as long as the body is in the vicinity of another massive body. In contrast, moral considerations may be not only counterbalanced, but also removed. For example, assume that it is *prima facie* right to make people happy. But now suppose that some particular act would produce happiness for a sadist by allowing him the pleasure of watching other people suffer. In this case, the point is not merely that the value of the sadist's

pleasure is outweighed by the suffering of his victims; rather, the sadistic nature of the enjoyment to be produced deprives it of any moral value. The sadist's pleasure is not a reason at all in favor of the proposed action.¹³

Now, one might think that this creates a problem for the very notion of *prima facie* rightness. Suppose that a *prima facie* right type of action is understood to be a type of action such that an act's being of that type counts as a reason in its favor. The sort of example we have just discussed shows that it is difficult to find any type of action such that an act's being of that type is always a reason in its favor—there can always, it seems, be further circumstances that neutralize any would-be reason in favor of an action.¹⁴

There are at least two ways we might respond to this. On the one hand, we might say that this sort of example only shows that one has misidentified what is *prima facie* right: it is not the production of happiness that is *prima facie* right, we might say, but the production of *innocent* pleasures. Alternately, we might simply liberalize the notion of *prima facie* rightness: we might say that when a type of action is *prima facie* right, then we have a reason to perform acts of that type *other things being equal, or in normal conditions*; this is compatible with the possibility of special circumstances that would neutralize this reason. Of course, we have not hereby produced a satisfactory moral theory—to do that, we would have to say much more, about such matters as which things are *prima facie* right and which sorts of considerations neutralize which sorts of reasons. All I am aiming at here is to defend intuitionism against the charge that it has available no coherent notion of how moral properties are related to natural properties.¹⁵

Consider a second analogy. No one doubts that there are objective facts about what is a good move in chess—not morally good, but good from the standpoint of winning and not losing the game. Whether a move is good supervenes on the arrangement of pieces on the board (perhaps together with the capacities of the players). There are rules that help one choose good moves: try to develop your pieces early, try to control the center of the board, rooks are more valuable than knights, and so on. All these rules are defeasible; some possible positions call for violating them. Nevertheless, these principles can be seen, rationally, to be correct. A person with no experience playing chess but who knew the rules and objective of the game could see that these things make sense.¹⁶ Furthermore, they are necessary truths. (It is contingent what the rules of the game are, but *given* these rules, it is necessary, in a manner similar to mathematical truths, that these rules represent generally good strategies.¹⁷)

This analogy refutes Strawson's contention that it cannot be necessary that some class of things *tend* to have some property. And it demonstrates the coherence of the intuitionist's conception of the relationship between evaluative and natural facts. It does not show that conception to be *correct*—perhaps morality is not like chess—but it shows the conception to be coherent, by showing that there actually exists a realm in which the facts and our reasoning about them exemplify the structure the intuitionist attributes to moral facts and moral reasoning.

*8.2.3 Blackburn's objection

Let $\$A\$$ be some act which is morally wrong. Let $\$N\$$ be the complete set of natural properties of $\$A\$$.¹⁸ According to Blackburn, proposition (2) below is analytically true, but (1) is not:

1. If $\$A\$$ has $\$N\$$, it is wrong.
2. If $\$A\$$ has $\$N\$$ and is wrong, then every action that has $\$N\$$ is wrong.

In other words, you can coherently hold (without thereby proving that you don't understand the concept of wrongness), ' $\$A\$$ has $\$N\$$ but isn't wrong'. But you cannot coherently hold, ' $\$A\$$ has $\$N\$$ and is wrong, but other things with exactly the same natural properties are not wrong'. Blackburn thinks that the realist cannot explain this. If wrongness is some extra property of $\$A\$$, which does not follow from $\$A\$$'s natural properties, then why shouldn't it be possible for there to be one object that has wrongness, and another object with the same natural properties but without wrongness?¹⁹

That (1) is not analytic follows from my earlier argument against analytic naturalism (section 4.2), so I will grant that. (2) follows from the principle of the supervenience of moral properties. But it is not at all obvious, as Blackburn assumes, that (2) is analytic, rather than a synthetic, necessary truth. For (2) to be analytic, there must be a way of substituting synonymous expressions into (2) that results in a truth of logic. Blackburn makes no attempt to demonstrate this, nor can I see any way of doing so. Still, let us grant for the sake of argument that (2) is analytic.

What does Blackburn think is the correct, anti-realist explanation for the analyticity of (2)? He thinks that if someone were to reject supervenience, 'it would betray the whole purpose for which we moralize, which is to choose, commend, rank,

approve, or forbid things on the basis of their natural properties'.²⁰ This is a very thin explanation. If we deleted 'on the basis of their natural properties' from that sentence, Blackburn would have no explanation at all. Why must we approve (etc.) things on the basis of their natural properties? Why, on an anti-realist view, would it be inappropriate to value things on whim, praising one action but, for no reason, condemning another, indistinguishable action? Blackburn just proposes as a brute fact that such attitudes would not count as moral.

Why, then, may not the moral realist propose the following brute fact: the concept of moral properties includes that they depend on natural properties? Even if this were all the realist had to say, his account would be no less explanatory than Blackburn's.

But the realist has available another explanation. Let us introduce the term 'good-making' as a predicate that can be applied, not to particular objects or events, but to features of objects or events. Good-making features are those that tend to make the thing that has them good (this is obviously related to the notion of *prima facie* rightness discussed above). For example, we can say, 'Pleasantness is good-making'. Analogously, we can say, 'Being-an-act-of-cruelty is wrong-making'. Now here is a hypothesis:
 (a) Our most fundamental moral intuitions are about facts of the form '\$F\$ is good-making', '\$G\$ is wrong-making', and so on. When a person says that intuitively, killing is wrong, he is really reporting the intuition that being-a-killing is wrong-making.
 (b) To say a thing is good is to say something like: its good-making features predominate over its bad-making features, or that its *total set* of natural features is good-making.²¹ This seems a plausible hypothesis, consistent with introspective evidence. If it is true, then it is analytic that if a thing is good, every qualitatively indistinguishable thing is also good. Analytically, the only way for a thing to be good is for its total set of natural properties to be good-making. It follows that any other object that has that total set of properties has a good-making total set of properties, and therefore is good. This gives Blackburn what he asked for: an explanation of why the supervenience of moral properties is analytic that does not imply that individual moral standards are analytic. The realist now fares better in solving Blackburn's puzzle than Blackburn himself does.

8.2.4 Jackson's objection

Frank Jackson argues that the supervenience of the moral on the non-moral is difficult to reconcile with the irreducibility of the moral. Assume that goodness supervenes on natural properties. There may be many possible ways for a thing to be good—many natural properties, that is, that would make a thing good. Let these natural properties be \$N_1\$, \$N_2\$, and so on. For each of them, it is necessary that anything that has them is good (that is the principle of supervenience). Since we are stipulating that {\$N_1, N_2, \dots\$} is a complete list of the possible ways for a thing to be good, it is also necessary that anything that is good has at least one of these properties. Therefore, there are two predicates, 'good' and '\$N_1\$ or \$N_2\$ or \$\dots\$', that apply to exactly the same things in every possible situation.²² If these predicates refer to the same property, this is unproblematic. But the intuitionist holds that there are two different properties here, a natural property and a non-natural one, and that 'good' refers to the non-natural one. Jackson's objection here is subtle: what a word refers to is normally determined by its usage—what sorts of things we apply it to, including which hypothetical situations we would apply it in. But 'good' and '\$N_1\$ or \$N_2\$ or \$\dots\$' have the same usage in that sense. So, even if there were two properties there, what would make it the case that our word 'good' referred to the non-natural property, rather than the natural one? Furthermore, even if there was something that made the word refer to the non-natural property, how would children learning the language learn that 'good' was supposed to refer to the non-natural property instead of the natural one?²³

I think that the answer to this is fairly straightforward for a full-blooded intuitionist. What a word refers to is determined not solely by what we apply it to, but also at least partly by speakers' intentions. When we think about certain kinds of events (say), we see intuitively that they have this further, evaluative property in addition to their natural properties, and we intend our word 'good' to refer to that property. We intend to refer to the supervenient property, not the subvenient one; to the property the recognition of which inherently constitutes a reason for action; to the simple property that explains what \$N_1\$, \$N_2\$, and so on have in common. Furthermore, when children first learn the language, they take 'good' to refer to goodness rather than to (\$N_1\$ or \$N_2\$ or \$\dots\$), because we assume by default that an unfamiliar word refers to the most simple, unified (as opposed to disjunctive) property consistent with its usage.

Jackson's objection really depends on a further assumption: 'Our minds do not house detectors of the nonnatural properties Mooreans believe in'. Given this assumption, Jackson correctly infers that 'the story about the acquisition of ethical language must be one about latching onto patterns in the naturalistic'.²⁴ Given that, it is indeed puzzling how 'good' could come to refer to anything other than some pattern of natural properties. But Jackson's assumption obviously begs the question against intuitionism, nor does he give any argument against the existence of ethical intuition. His

argument would thus have force only against someone who posited irreducible value properties but refused to countenance either intuition or any similar faculty for knowing them.

***8.2.5 An analogy: the supervenience of logical properties**

The logical properties of an argument supervene on the meanings and arrangement of the symbols it contains. This is in some respects analogous to the supervenience of value properties on non-evaluative properties. Just as it is impossible for two actions to differ in respect of rightness without differing in some natural property, so it is impossible for two arguments to differ in respect of validity without differing in the meaning or arrangement of their symbols. Just as an action's ethical properties are determined by its natural properties, an argument's logical properties are determined by the meanings and arrangement of its symbols (especially the logical symbols). And just as (many philosophers believe) there is nevertheless no general algorithm for determining what is morally right, there is no general algorithm for computing what is logically necessary. For the last claim, I rely on Gödel's Theorem, assuming that we wish to count the truths of arithmetic as logically necessary. (If you do not view truths of arithmetic as logically necessary, then substitute some notion of mathematical necessity here, and change the analogy to one of the supervenience of mathematical necessity on meanings.) This shows that these aspects of the doctrine of the supervenience of the ethical are perfectly coherent.

One disanalogy between ethics and deductive logic concerns the notion of *prima facie* rightness. There is no parallel notion of 'prima facie validity'; the rules of deductive logic tell us that inferences of certain kinds are always valid, not that they tend to be valid. We can, however, find an analogy to *prima facie* rightness if we look to non-demonstrative reasoning. It is possible that A non-demonstratively supports B but that, if certain further information, C, were added to one's background beliefs, A would no longer support B. We might then say that A is 'prima facie' evidence for B, or is evidence for B in normal conditions. For example, relative to a normal background belief system, Jim's attesting that he owns a motorcycle is good evidence that he owns a motorcycle. But if one also knows that Jim is a pathological liar who has been falsely posing as a motorcycle gang member for years, then Jim's testimony is no longer good evidence that he owns a motorcycle. It thus seems that non-deductive logic is analogous in the relevant respects to ethics. Yet no one suggests that these features of non-deductive logic—the fact that its relations of evidential support are supervenient and that they are defeasible—support anti-realism about evidential support.

8.3 How can we understand 'good'?

How do we initially learn the meaning of the word 'good'? There seem to be two ways of explaining the meaning of a word to someone. The first is to give a definition. But intuitionists deny that 'good' can be defined, so that is out. The second way is to specify some things the word applies to. For instance, one points to a number of dogs, saying 'dog', and the child gets the idea that the word refers to things of that type. One cannot point to goodness, since goodness is not perceivable by the senses, but perhaps one may tell a child some examples of things that are good, whereupon he gets the idea that 'good' refers to what those things have in common. The problem is that people disagree substantially about what is good, so how can it be established that they all mean the same thing by 'good'?

The suggestions of the previous paragraph about how words are learned are oversimplified. Hardly any of the vast vocabulary of an ordinary person is acquired through anyone's expressly teaching him the words, either by defining them or by giving him lists of examples. Nearly every word is learned by one's hearing it used in conversations in which no explicit effort to explain the word is made.

In any case, there is substantial agreement on what things are good, on an everyday level. Nearly everyone calls happiness, health, friendship, knowledge, and long life 'good'. Furthermore, people tend to pursue the things they call 'good', try to get other people to pursue them, and say things implying that the 'goodness' of a thing is a reason to pursue it. Children can learn that 'good' refers to goodness because that interpretation makes sense of most of the things that are said using the word, and no other, comparably simple interpretation comes close to doing that.

A related objection is that 'good' cannot refer to any one property, since so many utterly different things are called 'good'—people, actions, states of affairs, facts, events. This is a mistake—extremely dissimilar things may still have some abstract feature in common. Compare the fact that numbers can apply to physical objects, ideas, propositions, actions, and so on—'three' means the same thing in 'I have three pairs of shoes' and 'There are three main reasons for buying a PC'. Likewise for logical properties or relationships, such as identity and set membership, or metaphysical 'properties' such as existence or determinateness. Likewise, there is no obstacle to goodness' applying to widely disparate things.

8.4 Is intuitionism too subjective?

Some have accused intuitionism of devolving into a form of subjectivism. Some complain that intuitionists do not provide much of a method for arriving at moral conclusions, or that they provide no method for distinguishing correct from incorrect intuitions. The latter charge has been discussed previously (section 6.4). As to the absence of method, compare the 'method' by which we arrive at many physical-object beliefs: we perceive things, and then we believe things are the way we perceive them to be. This is a very simple 'method', but that does not impugn the objectivity of perceptual knowledge; no more, then, does the comparably simple intuitionist 'method' of coming by moral knowledge impugn the latter's objectivity.

Another version of the complaint is that intuitionism makes the truth of a moral theory depend upon its comporting with our intuitions and is therefore a form of subjectivism.²⁹ This is simply a misunderstanding of the theory. Intuition is our means of cognizing moral truths. It does not create moral truth, any more than perception creates truths about the physical world.

Still, it might be thought that intuitionism advocates a troublingly subjective epistemology, insofar as intuitions—mere internal mental states—are made the ultimate source of justification for all claims in some allegedly objective field. This objection, too, may rest on a misunderstanding: intuitionism as I understand it does not advocate appealing to intuitions as evidence from which to infer normative conclusions (see above, section 5.6). It does, however, hold that whether a moral belief is justified depends upon the believer's mental states, including his intuitions. A consequence of this is that justification is observer-relative: one person may be justified in believing what another is unjustified in believing. This, however, far from being an objectionable form of 'subjectivism', is true of all kinds of beliefs.³⁰ The justification for perceptual beliefs depends upon one's perceptual experiences. The justification for beliefs about the past depends upon one's memories. Inferential justification depends upon one's other beliefs. The fact that the justification for moral beliefs depends upon the believer's mental states is thus unsurprising and no cause for alarm.